

I. Enlightenment and Neoclassicism (1660–1800 CE)

This period, known as the **Age of Reason**, emphasized logic, scientific inquiry, and social reform.

- **Key Characteristics:** Writers valued reason and order, often using **satire** and wit to critique authority and human behavior.
- **Neoclassicism:** A revival of ancient Greek and Roman forms that prioritized balance, universal truths, and moral lessons.
- **Main Forms:**
 - **Reason:** Used to challenge traditions and encourage societal reform. Example: Voltaire's "Candide" critiques blind optimism.
 - **Satire:** Employs humor and irony to expose societal flaws. Example: Jonathan Swift's "A Modest Proposal" uses extreme exaggeration to criticize government indifference toward the poor.

Featured Work: Gulliver's Travels (Part I) by Jonathan Swift

- **Setting:** The fictional islands of **Lilliput** and **Blefuscu**, inhabited by people six inches tall.
 - **Summary:** Ship surgeon Lemuel Gulliver is shipwrecked on Lilliput. While initially a prisoner, he helps the Lilliputians defeat their rivals, the Blefuscudians, but grows frustrated by the tiny people's petty political disputes and pride.
 - **Themes:** Pride, vanity, and the relativity of perspective.
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II. Romanticism (1780–1850 CE)

Romanticism was a reaction against the cold logic of the Enlightenment, celebrating the individual and the emotional.

- **Key Concepts:**
 - **Emotion:** Personal experience and intense feelings (e.g., Wordsworth's poetry).

- **Nature:** Seen as a source of spiritual insight and power (e.g., Shelley's "Ode to the West Wind").
 - **Imagination:** Exploring fantasy and creativity (e.g., Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein*).
 - **The Sublime:** Experiences of overwhelming awe or terror, often linked to nature (e.g., Coleridge's "The Rime of the Ancient Mariner").
 - **Individualism:** Valuing personal freedom over societal expectations (e.g., Lord Byron's works).
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III. Realism and Naturalism (1850–1910 CE)

These movements sought to portray life accurately, focusing on everyday experiences and the influence of external forces.

- **Realism:** Focuses on ordinary people, moral choices, and social interactions.
- **Naturalism:** An extension of Realism that emphasizes **determinism**—how heredity, environment, and social conditions inevitably shape human behavior.
- **Main Forms:**
 - **Social Critique:** Exposing inequality and exploitation. Example: Émile Zola's "Germinal" portrays the harsh lives of coal miners.
 - **Detailed Characterization:** Using **psychological realism** to show how environment shapes personality.

Featured Work: The Adventures of Huckleberry Finn by Mark Twain

- **Setting:** Along the Mississippi River in 19th-century America.
- **Summary:** Huck Finn escapes his abusive father and travels down the river with **Jim**, a runaway slave. Huck faces an internal moral struggle, eventually choosing his friendship and loyalty to Jim over society's discriminatory laws.
- **Moral:** Freedom and doing what is right are more important than blindly following societal rules.

